

SPECIAL REPORT | **NAXALS IN CHHATTISGARH**

THE BIG SURRENDER

A CALIBRATED BLEND OF FORCE AND PERSUASION FUELS RECORD NAXALITE SURRENDERS IN BASTAR, SHAKING THEIR RANKS AND ACCELERATING THE PUSH TO END THE MOVEMENT

By **RAHUL NORONHA** *in Bastar*

At 11:30 pm, a district superintendent of police's phone rings in Chhattisgarh's Naxal-affected Bastar division. His eyes fix on the number flashing on the screen and his expression shifts—betraying a flicker of expectation. "*Woh baahar aane ko taiyyar hai* (he's ready to come out)," says the voice at the other end before hanging up.

The "*woh*" is a high-value Naxal/ Maoist who, along with 30 cadres, has agreed to lay down arms under 'Poona Margam' (new path), a grassroots rehabilitation programme meant to steer former insurgents back into society. And this is no isolated call. Bastar is witnessing a flurry of surrenders: 1,513 Naxals have laid down weapons this year alone. On paper, it's a win-win for both sides—the insurgents looking for a way out and a regime pushing for peace. But coaxing Naxals to surrender—and navigating the politics around it—is anything but simple.